

PROJECT PROPOSAL / SYNOPSIS

INDIRA GANDHI NATIONAL OPEN UNIVERSITY

B.A. TOURISM STUDIES (BTS)

Candidate Information (to be filled by the candidate)

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Project Proposal - Topic

Role of Salugara Monastery in Promoting Buddhist Cultural Tourism in Siliguri Region

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Introduction

Project Proposal - Topic: Role of Salugara Monastery in Promoting Buddhist Cultural Tourism in Siliguri Region

Tourism in contemporary India increasingly values experience quality, heritage meaning, and local cultural authenticity. Within this context, Buddhist cultural tourism has emerged as an important segment because it combines pilgrimage, spiritual travel, heritage learning, and intercultural contact. The Siliguri region is strategically located as a movement gateway toward Darjeeling hills, Kalimpong, Sikkim, and adjoining Himalayan circuits. This mobility context gives religious-cultural destinations in and around Siliguri high tourism potential, even when they are not formally marketed as major stand-alone attractions.

Salugara Monastery, known for its visible stupa and spiritual environment, is one such destination that attracts diverse visitor groups. These include practicing Buddhists, peace-seeking domestic travelers, architecture-curious visitors, and transit tourists who stop for short visits while moving to nearby hill destinations. Local residents and small businesses also interact with this visitor flow, creating social and economic linkages that deserve closer academic examination. However, much of the narrative around the site remains informal, and there is limited student-level field documentation integrating culture, tourism behaviour, and community outcomes in one framework.

The proposed study is designed as a focused case-based investigation under the PTS-1 theme of Indian Culture, Environment and Tourism. It aims to understand how Salugara Monastery contributes to Buddhist cultural tourism and how its strengths can be supported through respectful destination practices. The study is guided by the principle that sacred institutions should not be treated as commercial attractions in a conventional sense; tourism interventions should therefore protect sanctity while improving visitor understanding and local benefit.

Review of Literature

Literature on cultural tourism argues that destinations perform best when tangible heritage and intangible practices are interpreted together. In religious contexts, visitor satisfaction is shaped not only by architecture and visuals but also by ritual atmosphere, authenticity, and emotional safety. Several scholars in heritage tourism have emphasized that sacred sites are living institutions; therefore, visitor management must respect site-specific codes rather than apply generic mass-tourism models.

Pilgrimage tourism studies show that motivation is often layered: devotion may coexist with curiosity, personal reflection, and educational intent. This mixed motivation pattern is important for monasteries, where some visitors seek formal prayer engagement while others seek peace, quiet, and cultural learning. Existing work in religious tourism also indicates that first-time visitors benefit significantly from clear interpretation support, especially when local symbols and ritual etiquette are unfamiliar.

Significance & Context

Tourism planning literature on medium-scale gateway cities suggests that transit geography can create under-recognized destination opportunities. Sites that are not primary endpoints can still become meaningful stops if route readability, communication quality, and local partnerships are improved. In the Siliguri context, this insight is highly relevant because large numbers of travelers already move across regional circuits toward hill destinations. Salugara can therefore be studied as both a destination and a culturally meaningful pause-point in broader visitor movement.

Sustainable tourism scholarship adds that local acceptance depends on fairness of benefit distribution and visible management of externalities. Around religious destinations, recurring challenges include unstructured parking, litter pressure, unclear wayfinding, and etiquette non-compliance by uninformed visitors. Studies consistently indicate that low-cost interventions such as multilingual signage, orientation support, and coordinated cleanliness systems can significantly improve visitor experience quality.

Policy references from Government of India show continuing interest in Buddhist tourism development through thematic circuit initiatives. However, local feeder destinations often require site-specific planning support to translate macro policy momentum into practical outcomes. This creates a strong context for a field study that examines how a locally important monastery can align sacred integrity with responsible visitor access.

The proposed study is significant because it links culture, tourism behaviour, and local livelihood evidence in one integrated framework. It can contribute to academic understanding, inform community-level destination discussions, and offer a replicable model for similar Buddhist cultural nodes in regional gateway settings. The analytical lens remains sacred-first, ensuring that tourism recommendations strengthen understanding and respect rather than commercialize ritual spaces.

The context is also socially important because Salugara is not simply a tourist viewing point; it is a lived cultural institution for practicing communities. Any increase in visitor flow can influence everyday site rhythms, prayer conditions, and neighborhood usage patterns. If tourism expansion is proposed without contextual sensitivity, community resistance may rise and the very values attracting visitors may weaken. For this reason, the study deliberately frames tourism not as volume maximization but as quality-centered engagement where information clarity, visitor etiquette, and respectful movement are prioritized.

Significance & Context (continued)

Another dimension of significance lies in educational value. A large segment of first-time visitors to Buddhist monasteries are unfamiliar with symbolic vocabulary, ritual boundaries, and behavioural norms. When interpretation is absent, the visitor experience often remains superficial and confusion-related mistakes increase. The proposed work can help establish an interpretation logic suited to living sacred spaces: concise, non-intrusive, multilingual, and culturally accurate. This is especially useful for student-level tourism planning because it connects theory with practical communication design.

From an economic viewpoint, monastery-linked tourism in corridor regions generally supports micro-level enterprise systems rather than large consolidated operators. Tea stalls, local transport, small retail, and occasional local services may all benefit, but gains can remain uneven when visits are short and fragmented. By studying spending tendencies and perceived local benefit channels, the project can identify which low-investment measures might improve dwell time and local value capture while retaining sacred character. This makes the study relevant for inclusive destination planning discussions.

Environmentally, the context is equally significant. Even moderate tourist growth can produce cumulative pressure in compact approach zones through litter, noise, informal parking, and circulation congestion. Such pressures are manageable only when responsibilities are clearly distributed among site stakeholders, local civic agencies, and visitor-support services. The synopsis therefore positions sustainability as a practical management question rather than an abstract policy slogan.

At a broader regional scale, the Siliguri setting offers potential for clustered Buddhist cultural experiences. Yet cluster potential is meaningful only if each node is interpreted within its local identity and carrying context. This study contributes by grounding recommendations in one specific case instead of relying on generic destination templates. The expected output is not a one-size model but a transferable method: document local realities, classify stakeholder priorities, and design phased actions that preserve cultural dignity while improving visitor preparedness.

In summary, the Significance & Context of this proposal extends across six linked levels: cultural preservation, visitor literacy, community acceptance, micro-economy linkage, environmental responsibility, and evidence-based regional planning. This multi-layer relevance justifies the proposed two-page treatment and supports the need for a structured, field-backed PTS-1 project in the present topic area.

Objective of the Study

Primary Objective: To examine the role of Salugara Monastery in promoting Buddhist cultural tourism in the Siliguri region and to develop recommendations for respectful and sustainable destination improvement.

Specific Objectives: 1. To profile the types of visitors, their motivations, and movement patterns at Salugara Monastery. 2. To assess how the monastery communicates and preserves Buddhist cultural values for visitors. 3. To identify local economic linkages associated with monastery-related visitor flow. 4. To evaluate infrastructure, interpretation, and management gaps affecting visitor experience. 5. To formulate practical recommendations that balance sanctity, learning, and tourism utility.

Scope and Delimitation: The study focuses on Salugara as the main case and uses nearby monastery references only where useful for contextual comparison. The work is designed for academic analysis and does not include financial auditing of religious institutions. Findings will be interpreted as grounded case evidence rather than universal claims for all Buddhist destinations.

Methodology

Research Design: The proposed design is mixed-method, combining quantitative survey inputs with qualitative interviews and structured observation. This approach is suitable because the topic includes measurable indicators (visitor profile, satisfaction cues, spending tendency) and interpretive dimensions (sacred boundaries, cultural understanding, local perceptions).

Data Sources: Primary data will be collected through visitor questionnaires, stakeholder interviews, and observational field notes. Secondary data will include IGNOU materials, official tourism statistics, policy notes, and selected published literature relevant to cultural and religious tourism.

Indicative Sampling Plan: - Visitor survey respondents at site entry/exit windows. - Monastic/management interviews for institutional perspective. - Local business and resident interviews for community linkage evidence. - Observations across weekday and weekend periods to capture variation.

Tools: Annexure-linked tools will be used: visitor questionnaire, monastic interview schedule, local stakeholder interview schedule, and structured observation checklist. These tools are attached in synopsis annexure so that supervisor can review methodological fit before field deployment.

Methodology (continued)

Data Handling and Analysis: Survey entries will be tabulated and interpreted through basic percentage logic. Interview notes will be coded into themes such as heritage meaning, visitor conduct, infrastructure concern, and economic linkage. Observational inputs will be used to validate or challenge respondent perceptions. Contradictory findings will be documented rather than removed to preserve analytical integrity.

Work Plan: Stage 1: Tool finalization and supervisor consultation. Stage 2: Field data collection and concurrent field notes. Stage 3: Data classification, thematic coding, and chapter drafting. Stage 4: Final writing, bibliography completion, annexure alignment, and formatting.

Ethical and Practical Considerations: Interactions will be voluntary and non-intrusive. No personal-sensitive details will be published without consent. Ritual spaces will be approached respectfully, and data collection will avoid prayer disruption. The methodology is designed to produce academically valid yet practically usable findings for BTS- level project evaluation.

Conclusion

The proposed study is academically relevant and operationally feasible within the BTS framework. It aligns with PTS-1 expectations by linking Indian cultural context, fieldwork evidence, and practical tourism analysis. Salugara Monastery offers a strong case context because it combines sacred identity, tourism visibility, and local socio- economic interaction in a compact regional setting.

The synopsis argues that meaningful Buddhist cultural tourism development must follow a sacred-first logic: cultural dignity and monastic norms remain central, while visitor interpretation and community participation are strengthened through careful planning. The project is expected to generate recommendations that are realistic for local stakeholders and useful for future student research.

In summary, the proposal is designed to move from descriptive narration to evidence-based analysis. By integrating visitor behaviour, institutional perspective, and local linkage data, the study intends to provide a balanced and responsible tourism framework for Salugara and comparable cultural destinations.

Reference

1. IGNOU. Project Guide BTS (PTS-1, PTS-2), valid from July 2021 session. 2. Ministry of Tourism, Government of India. State/UT-wise Domestic and Foreign Tourist Visits (2021-2022). 3. PIB, Government of India. Buddhist Thematic Circuit under Swadesh Darshan Scheme (2025 release). 4. PIB, Ministry of Tourism. Attracting Tourists to Buddhist Circuits (2026 release). 5. Richards, G. Cultural Tourism: Trends and Research Perspectives. 6. Timothy, D. and Boyd, S. Heritage Tourism. Routledge. 7. Swarbrooke, J. Sustainable Tourism Management. CABI. 8. UNWTO publications on culture-linked and religious tourism. 9. Selected field preparation notes and draft tool schedules prepared by researcher.

ANNEXURE TO SYNOPSIS

Annexure to Synopsis (Proposed Research Tools): - Annexure A: Visitor Questionnaire - Annexure B: Monastic/Management Interview Schedule - Annexure C: Local Business and Resident Interview Schedule - Annexure D: Structured Observation Checklist

Note: These tools are attached for supervisor review at synopsis stage. Final project annexure will include revised versions actually used in fieldwork.

LETTER/CERTIFICATE OF APPROVAL (By the Supervisor)

I hereby certify that the proposal for the Project entitled _____ by _____ has been prepared after due consultation with me. The proposal has my approval and has, to my knowledge, the potential of developing into a comprehensive Project Work. I also agree to supervise the above mentioned Project till its completion.

Signature of the Supervisor: _____ Name: _____ Designation: _____
Address: _____

Checklist: Keep one copy with yourself. Submit one signed proposal copy to Programme Coordinator (BTS/BAVTM), SOTHSM, IGNOU.